



Boundary-work in management accounting: The case of hybrid professionalism

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ABSTRACT

This paper investigates boundary-work in management accounting in the context of globalization and hybrid professionalism. The paper demonstrates how permeable symbolic boundaries of the management accounting field can be altered by employing expansion boundary-work. Contrasting boundary-work of IMA officials and IMA members in Russia, we show that IMA officials employ primarily monopolization boundary-work while IMA members employ primarily expansion boundary-work. Our findings illustrate how boundary-work is employed to exhibit organizational and occupational professionalism in the symbolic realm. The paper provides additional insight into the discursive domain of the accounting profession by linking boundary-work to globalization, two forms of professionalism, legitimacy, status and professional identity. This suggests that the professionalization process is influenced by the properties of professional boundaries.

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1. Introduction

The professionalization process is associated with the construction of symbolic and social boundaries (Annisette, 2017; Lamont & Molnár, 2002). Professionalization studies in accounting have focused primarily on understanding the maintenance and protection of social boundaries and theorizing professional closure (Carnegie & Napier, 2010; Chua & Poullaos, 1998; Ramirez, 2001). Only a few studies in accounting have considered the construction of symbolic boundaries as a form of boundary-work (Annisette, 2017; Gracia & Oats, 2012; Hazgui & Gendron, 2015). Boundary-work is a specific type of linguistic practice used to distinguish one professional group from another (Annisette, 2017; Gieryn, 1983). Boundary-work is of crucial importance to the professionalization project because it is used to gain legitimacy and autonomy, negotiate professional boundaries, exclude outsiders and define professional identity (Annisette, 2017; Liljegren, 2012b; Mikes, 2011; Wikström, 2008).

The objective of this study is to examine boundary-work in the field of management accounting. While previous studies investigated boundary-work in the fields of financial accounting and auditing, which have relatively stable professional boundaries (Annisette, 2017; Hazgui & Gendron, 2015), this study aims to expand our understanding of the notion of boundary-work by focusing on the field of management accounting, which has more permeable professional boundaries. This paper contrasts the boundary-work of the official representatives of a professional association with the boundary-work of its members. While professional associations are considered to play a major role in the publicly conducted boundary-work (Annisette, 2017), little is known about the boundary-work of professionals as individuals. Liljegren (2012b) has argued

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